

HERO'S JOURNEY

Also known as the Monomyth, the hero's journey is a template or a set of common elements to a number of mythological and pop culture stories. The hero sets out on an adventure, goes through trials, wins a gift, transforms himself, and comes back to save or change the world. The story is set in three acts of departure, initiation and return. Joseph Campbell described seventeen steps in The Hero with a Thousand Faces while David Adams Leeming and Christopher Vogler have also outlined the same basic structure, with fewer steps. Here we show how the stories of some popular heros fits into the journey.

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Birth of the Hero

Typically, the Hero is born under unusual circumstances, and there may even be a prophecy of the great things to come.

Harry Potter is protected by the sacrifice of his mother, and is known as "The Boy Who Lived". He is prophesized to eventually destroy The Dark Lord.
 Luke Skywalker lives in relative anonymity as a moisture farmer on Tatooine, and could be one of the people who brings balance to the force.
 Thomas Anderson, or "The One" is prophesized to end the war between man and machine. Secretly, he is also a hacker.
 Frodo receives The One Ring from Bilbo, a Hobbit who has started to live for an unusually long time.
 Thor is on track to ascend the throne of Asgard, replacing his father, Odin.
 Arya Stark is the daughter of the Hand of the King, and has a Direwolf pet, Nymeria.
 Jake is a paraplegic who is paralysed from the waist down.

Jake is asked to replace his twin brother as an Avatar Driver, and is dispatched to the moon of Pandora.

Jaquen H'ghar invites Arya to the House of Black and White across the narrow sea, where she can learn the skills of becoming a Faceless Man.

Odin wants to teach Thor some humility, so he strips Thor of all his powers and banishes him to the Earth.

Gandalf tells Frodo that his life is in danger because of the servants of Sauron, and he needs to flee to Rivendell with The One Ring.

Trinity asks Anderson to follow the white rabbit as "The Matrix" has him, and encourages him to "wake up".

A droid that Skywalker buys, broadcasts a message from Princess Leia asking for help.

Hogwarts sends a letter to Harry informing him about a reserved seat. Hagrid rescues Harry from the Dursleys.

Call to Adventure

The hero sets out to save the world in some way or another, and must embark on a journey into a fantastical or supernatural realm. Typically helped at this stage by a mentor figure.

Crossing the Threshold

The hero leaves behind the familiar world that he grew up in, and ventures into the unknown. There may or may not be threshold guardians to test the mettle of the hero.

There is a literal barrier where this happens in the series, as Potter has to run into a wall on platform 9 and 3/4.

Skywalker leaves Tatooine, undergoes training under Obi Wan Kenobi, and joins the Rebel Alliance.

Anderson takes the red pill, and wakes up in a pod. A robot disconnects him from wires and cables, and dumps him into a sewer system.

Escaping from the black riders and leaving Bree with Aragorn, the Hobbits have never left the Shire before.

Eric Selvig helps Thor find himself, and Thor takes on the Destroyer even though he knows that he has a slim chance.

Arya leaves Winterfell to go to King's Landing, then escapes to Harrenhal, and finally heads to Braavos on Essos.

Jake steps into the Avatar for the first time, is surprisingly good at controlling it, and enjoys the ability to walk.

Jake escapes from Pandoran predators, and is prevented from being killed by Neytiri because of a sign from Ehwa.

Arya undergoes a series of tests to become a Faceless Man. In fact, her whole life has been a series of trials up to this point in time.

Thor takes on multiple enemies, and also fights alongside the Avengers.

Frodo encounters orcs, black riders, and Boromir, who attempt to steal the Ring. He is also captured and then released by Faramir.

Anderson undergoes a training process of living in the real world and operating within the Matrix.

Skywalker destroys the Death Star, forms the Rogue Squadron, and fights the Empire.

Potter defeats Quirrel, proves the innocence of Hagrid, saves Sirius black, and wins the Triwizard Tournament.

Trials and Quest

The hero goes through a series of trials, which are often of increasing difficulty. The hero may even fail at one or more of these trials.

The ordeal

Also known as the Night Sea Voyage, the hero has to enter the secret base of the enemy, vanquish the dragon, and maybe retrieve an item or person.

The battle for Howarts is where it all goes down, and Harry has to make a last stand against the forces of Voldemort.

After the defeat of the Empire, Luke wants to rebuild the Jedi Order, but his own nephew turns to the dark side of the force.

Morpheus and Trinity are rescued, but Agent Smith prevents Neo from getting out of the Matrix, and Neo can only run.

Frodo has to make a long arduous trek into Mordor, with an unreliable Gollum. The hobbits and Gollum have to make do with limited food and water.

Thor undergoes a transformation, losing his eye and his hammer.

Arya confronts the Wraith in a pitch dark setting, and it is a fight to the death.

Jake learns to hunt and live like the natives, greatly impressing them with his feats. Jake also manages to tame a Toruk.